Be that as it may, the committee did end up defanging the cow slaughter issue for a few years. The Jan Sangh's 1971 manifesto, for example, did not mention it.

Interestingly, Indira Gandhi herself was very circumspect on cow slaughter. Jairam Ramesh unearthed a 1967 letter from then American ambassador Chester Bowles to Dillon Ripley, who was at the Smithsonian Institution. Ripley wanted to study the ecological consequences of India's large cattle population. Bowles replied that the prime minister did not like this idea because it was a sensitive issue and must be dealt with only by Indians.[143]

Historically, while the issue of cow slaughter has remained a central tenet of the Jan Sangh's—and later the BJP's—worldview, the importance placed on it has ebbed and flowed with the politics of the time. A case in point is the environment ministry's guidelines in May 2017 which restricted sale of cattle for slaughter. This had a huge impact on states like West Bengal, Kerala and several Northeast states, where cow slaughter is not banned.

Apart from the immediate political (and human) impact of a rise in lynchings of suspected cow smugglers, the cultural impulse for protecting cows also had an immediate economic impact. For instance, Tamil Nadu's leather industry, which is a major export-earning industry and a major employer, was badly affected. 'I am not surprised Tamil Nadu has been vociferous,' Jairam Ramesh, who was also once the Union environment minister, told me. 'There is an economic angle which also needs to be looked at.'

In UP, for instance, the economic offshoot was that panic prevailed in the ₹50,000-crore meat industry after a state-wide crackdown on illegal slaughter houses and mechanised abattoirs initiated by Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath in May 2017. Officially, the state government stated that it was only acting against illegal units, but the closure of some slaughterhouses with a valid licence in western UP set alarm bells ringing.[144]

As All India Meat and Livestock Exports Association (AIMLEA) Secretary Fauzan Alavi told a newspaper at the time, 'A licensed exporter, for example, can't even think of slaughtering a cow—not because it's legally banned, but also because we share the same sentiments for the holy animal as our Hindu brethren. But, suddenly